

Is a Business Degree Worth It in the AI Era?

The planning guide — the full scores by track, the six factors behind them, the honest trade-offs, and what to ask before you commit.

7.6

AI EXPOSURE · BUSINESS ANALYST / COORDINATOR
where 10 is most at risk

For anyone still choosing — read it straight through.



Before you read this

You're weighing a business degree — or a path into business — and you want to know what that choice actually looks like in an AI economy. That's the whole job of this guide.

It's written to you directly, whether you are the one choosing or a parent thinking it through alongside them. Where it says "you," a parent can read "them"; it's the same decision from either side.

What this is. A facts document, not a recommendation. It sets out what's known, where the evidence is contested, and where we might be wrong — and then how to choose well given all of it.

If you're the parent, a note on how to use it. Don't lead with the scores. Open a conversation with a risk number and one of two things happens: they shut down, or they get defensive about a choice they're already leaning toward. Read it yourself first, then share it as information you both react to, not a verdict you've reached. They're choosing, not you — the job is to widen what's been considered, not to narrow it.

And one thing specific to business. It's the most-taken degree in the country, which makes it the default — the thing people pick when nothing else stood out. That's the single most important fact here, and it isn't about AI at all. If the interest is genuine — how organizations work, why they succeed and fail — this guide will help you choose the version that holds up. If business is the fallback because nothing else appealed, the honest move is to stop and look wider first.

The short answer

A general business degree with no specialization, no placement and no analytical depth is one of the weaker bets in this index. The versions that work are specific — and choosing one of those versions is most of the decision in front of you.

Business analyst and coordinator roles score **7.6** out of 10. General management with real accountability scores **4.9**.

And here is the thing that separates business from every other career we score: look at what's missing from that range. Nothing sits below 4.9. Every other profession in this index has a protected core. Business has a protected ceiling — so the choice isn't "is business safe," it's "which version of it points at the ceiling."

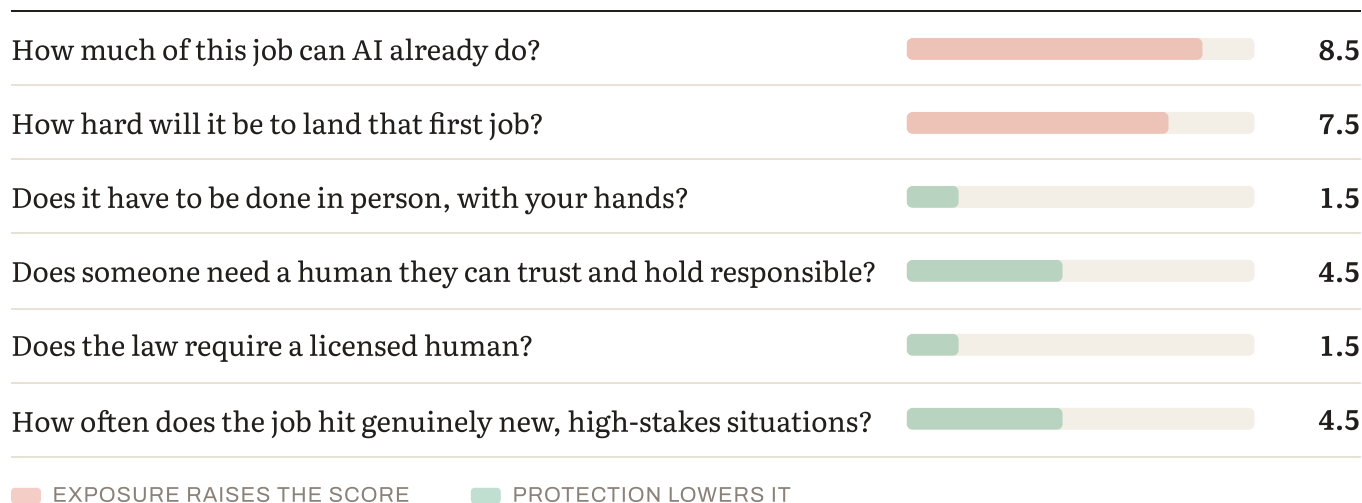
The scores

DESTINATION	2023	2025	FALL 2026	3-YR MOVEMENT	BAND
General management / P&L ownership	4.2	4.5	4.9	+0.7	Moderate
Supply chain & operations	4.3	4.6	5.0	+0.7	Moderate
HR / people	4.7	5.0	5.3	+0.6	Moderate
Project management	5.3	5.7	6.1	+0.8	Moderate–High
Business analyst / coordinator	6.2	7.0	7.6	+1.4	High

Scores run 1–10, where 10 is most at risk. For context: the median profession in this edition sits around 5.5, bedside nursing scores 2.8, a service electrician scores 2.5, and entry-level software development scores 8.1.

Read the table this way: the spread is 2.7 points, which is narrower than law's or medicine's. That sounds reassuring and isn't. The range is narrow because the whole field sits in the middle — there is no safe end to retreat to. Which is why, with business, which version you choose matters more than the subject itself.

Why business scores the way it does — the six factors



Here's how a business analyst answers them — the exposed end, and where most graduates start. Knowing *why* the entry roles score 7.6 is what tells you which version of the degree to choose.

HOW MUCH OF THIS JOB CAN AI ALREADY DO? (35% OF THE SCORE)

More than almost any non-technical office role we score.

Report building and dashboard maintenance. Deck assembly. Market and competitor research. Process documentation. Requirements gathering and write-up. Meeting notes, trackers, status reporting.

The pattern here is unusually clean, and it's worth stating plainly: **almost everything on that list is what an entry-level business graduate was hired to do.**

What resists: owning a number and answering for it, managing people, negotiating with someone whose interests differ from yours, and deciding what should be measured in the first place. A degree worth choosing is one that builds toward those.

HOW HARD WILL IT BE TO LAND THAT FIRST JOB? (15%)

Bad, and worse than the automation alone would suggest — because two forces are compressing the same rung.

The first is automation. Analyst programs, coordinator roles and junior project management are precisely the automatable layer. Firms that once hired three graduates to build the reports now hire one experienced person with tooling.

The second has nothing to do with AI, and our framework doesn't measure it: **plain oversupply.** Business is the most-conferred bachelor's degree in the United States. There is no licensing body

capping entry, no clinical placement bottleneck, no accreditation constraint on numbers.

The evidence section below covers what the labor market data actually shows, because it's the most important evidence in this guide.

The way through the Catch-22 isn't to wait for the entry rung to come back — it may not. It's to enter *beside* it: through a placement that substitutes for the vanishing analyst years, through a protected lane rather than the generic one, and with a result you can point to instead of a CV that reads like everyone else's. That's a set of concrete moves, not a hope — and choosing a program that makes them possible is exactly what the second half of this guide is about.

DOES IT HAVE TO BE DONE IN PERSON, WITH YOUR HANDS? (15%)

Effectively none of it.

Business work is meetings, documents, spreadsheets and decisions. There is no physical component to protect it — and unlike law or accounting, no licensing to compensate. The exception is operations and supply chain, which touch real-world constraints, and score marginally better for it.

DOES SOMEONE NEED A HUMAN THEY CAN TRUST AND HOLD RESPONSIBLE? (15%)

At the top, genuinely. At the bottom, not at all.

A general manager owns a P&L and answers for it. That accountability is real, it attaches to a person, and it's the main thing holding the top of this profession at 4.9 rather than 6.5.

An analyst produces work someone else presents. The protection in business exists — but it is entirely seniority-dependent, and a graduate has none of it. So the version of the degree that gets you to accountability fastest is the one that ages best.

DOES THE LAW REQUIRE A LICENSED HUMAN? (10%)

No. Nothing.

This is business's defining structural weakness, and it is permanent. No professional body controls entry. No statute reserves any management activity to a qualified person. Compare accounting, where the audit signature is a legal monopoly, or nursing, where scope-of-practice rules and staffing ratios are written into law.

Business has no floor beneath it. Whatever protection someone has, they earned personally. That's worth knowing going in: the degree opens doors, but it guarantees nothing on its own.

HOW OFTEN DOES THE JOB HIT GENUINELY NEW, HIGH-STAKES SITUATIONS? (10%)

At senior level often; at junior level rarely.

A managing director deciding whether to enter a market faces genuine novelty. An analyst producing a requested dashboard does not.

What the trend shows

Business analyst: 6.2 → 7.0 → 7.6. Up 1.4 points in three years.

General management: 4.2 → 4.5 → 4.9. Up 0.7.

Every destination moved, and none moved slowly. That is unusual. In most professions we score, the protected end barely shifts — bedside nursing moved 0.7, surgery 0.3. In business, even the most protected destination moved 0.7, because there is nothing structural holding it still.

The gap widened from 2.0 points to 2.7. The ladder's top is holding better than its bottom, but the whole ladder is drifting — which is the case for choosing the protected version deliberately rather than assuming you'll drift up to it.

How durable is the protection?

PROTECTION	STRENGTH TODAY	DURABILITY	WHERE THE PRESSURE IS COMING FROM
Human trust / accountability	Real at senior level	Durable	Someone must answer for the number. Socially and commercially rooted.
Judgment under novelty	Real at senior level	Eroding	Decision support is improving; genuine strategic novelty is not automating.
Regulatory / licensing	None	n/a	No license exists and none is coming.
Physical / embodied	None	n/a	Except in operations and supply chain, which is why those score marginally better.

The honest read. Business has two of the four protections, both of them seniority-dependent, and neither inherited from the profession. A doctor is protected on day one by a license. A manager is protected only once they have something to be accountable for.

That's the central fact to choose around: the protection is real, but it's earned — so the right question about any program is how quickly it gets you toward something you can be accountable for.

How the role will actually change

WAS THE JOB	IS BECOMING THE JOB
Building the report	Deciding what the report should measure
Running the analysis	Interrogating an analysis that arrived pre-built
Coordinating the project	Owning whether it delivers
Producing the deck	Standing behind what it argues
Learning the business by assembling its numbers	Learning it... some other way, still being worked out

The last row is the real problem. Generations of managers learned how a business actually worked by building its reports — you cannot assemble a P&L pack for two years without understanding the company. That was tedious, and it was also the education. Nobody has yet built a replacement. A program that has thought about this — how students learn the business when the grunt work is automated — is worth more than one that hasn't.

Human strengths that will matter most

1. **Accountability for an outcome** — the willingness to own a number publicly. The single most protective attribute in this field. 2. **Managing people** — hiring, developing, and having difficult conversations. Barely touched by any of this. 3. **Negotiation** — dealing with someone whose interests genuinely differ from yours. 4. **Deciding what to measure** — the judgment upstream of the analysis, rather than the analysis itself. 5. **Verification** — knowing when a generated analysis is confidently wrong, which requires understanding the business well enough to smell it.

Notably absent: producing decks, building models and assembling reports. These were the traditional markers of a strong graduate hire and are the fastest-depreciating things on the list. When comparing programs, it's worth checking which list the degree actually develops.

And underneath all five, two traits the score can't grade: **curiosity and adaptability**. The specific tools will turn over many times across a career — the people who compound are the ones who stay genuinely curious and re-tool fastest, rather than defending the one way of working they learned. In a field with no license and no fixed toolkit, that flexibility is itself a form of protection, and it's the thing employers are increasingly hiring for: the trajectory, not the current skill set.

The evidence that matters most — and it isn't about AI

This is the section to weigh most heavily, because it's the strongest data in this guide and it comes from an independent source.

The **Federal Reserve Bank of New York** tracks labor market outcomes for recent graduates. As of Q1 2026:

- Recent graduate unemployment stood at **5.7%**, against a national rate of 4.2%
- **Underemployment — working in a job that doesn't require a degree — sat at 41.5%**
- Recent-graduate unemployment has now exceeded the national rate for five consecutive years, something that was almost unheard of between 1990 and 2018

A separate Burning Glass Institute and Strada study found **52% of bachelor's degree holders were underemployed a year after graduation** — and, importantly, that those who start underemployed tend to stay that way.

Now the comparison that should shape the decision. Nursing has the lowest underemployment rate of any major the New York Fed tracks, at **12.8%**. Against a graduate average of 41.5%.

That gap is not about intelligence, effort or prestige. It is about whether a degree points at a **specific job that legally requires it**. Nursing does. General business does not — which is exactly why the version you choose, and what you do with it, carries so much weight.

This is why we say business's problem is not primarily AI. Automation is compressing the entry rung, and it's real. But it's arriving on top of a graduate market where four in ten degree-holders are already working in jobs that don't need a degree — and business, as the most-conferred degree in the country with no cap on numbers, sits at the center of that.

Our framework measures automation exposure. It cannot see oversupply. **For business specifically, the thing we can't measure may matter more than the thing we can, and we'd rather say so than pretend the score is the whole picture.**

Other things worth knowing

What's genuinely good about it

The destinations are genuinely good. General management, operations leadership and commercial roles are well paid, intellectually varied, and carry real autonomy. Business and finance occupations are projected to grow 6–7% — solid, if unspectacular.

What people in these roles report as rewarding:

- **Breadth** — few careers touch as many parts of an organization
- **Visible impact** — decisions produce results you can see
- **Pace of progression** — competence advances faster here than in credentialed professions
- **Optionality** — the skills transfer across industries and geographies more easily than most
- **A realistic route to ownership** — business is one of the few paths where starting your own is a normal outcome rather than an exotic one

And one genuine advantage over the licensed professions: nobody can stop you. There's no board, no registration, no scope of practice. The same absence that removes the floor also removes the ceiling.

What's genuinely hard about it

Getting the first job — the dominant risk, covered above.

Proving value without a credential. A nurse is a nurse. A business graduate is a claim that has to be substantiated repeatedly, especially early.

The middle is crowded. Progression from analyst to manager is the bottleneck, and it's where the automation is landing hardest.

Outcomes are unusually school- and program-dependent. Not because of prestige, but because placement programs, employer relationships and specialization vary enormously — and those, not the degree title, determine the first job. That's the single biggest reason to choose the program carefully.

Who this work suits — and who it doesn't

Business tends to reward people who:

- **Are comfortable being accountable in public** — this is the core protective trait
- **Genuinely like organizations** — how they work, why they fail, what makes people move
- **Can be useful without being told what to do.** The single biggest differentiator early on.
- **Are commercially curious** — interested in why something makes money, not just that it does

It's harder for people who want clear structure and defined tasks (that's exactly the automating layer), who need a credential to feel qualified, or who chose it because nothing else appealed. That last one is the honest one — the default-choice group is heavily over-represented among the underemployed, and it's worth facing before enrolling, not after.

What else is moving this market

Oversupply is the dominant force, and it's structural rather than cyclical. Nothing caps the number of business graduates.

Skills-based hiring is being announced more than practiced. A Burning Glass and Harvard Business School analysis found that removing degree requirements from postings hasn't meaningfully changed who gets hired.

Internships have become the actual filter. NACE's employer survey rates internship experience **4.5 out of 5** as a hiring factor — the highest-rated item. **In a field with no license, the placement is the closest thing to one** — which is why a program's placement record should weigh more in your decision than its name.

The AI-native advantage — what to actually do about it

The situation: business is where AI adoption is fastest, because there's nothing slowing it down — no regulator, no licensing body, no safety case to make. That cuts both ways. The exposure is higher, and so is the opportunity for someone who can direct it. A good program should be building this fluency deliberately, not banning the tools or ignoring them.

WHAT AN AI-NATIVE BUSINESS GRADUATE LOOKS LIKE

1. Verify. Knowing when a generated analysis is confidently wrong. This requires understanding the business well enough to smell an implausible number — which is exactly the

understanding the old report-building years used to produce.

2. Frame. Deciding what question is worth asking. The analysis is now cheap; knowing what to analyze is not.

3. Automate visibly. Being the person who rebuilds a manual process and can show what it saved. In a field with no credential, demonstrable results are the credential.

4. Communicate under scrutiny. Standing behind a recommendation when someone senior pushes back.

5. Own something measurable, early. The whole guide points at accountability. Anything that puts a graduate closer to a number they answer for moves them up the scale.

CONCRETE PREPARATION

Choosing the program: weight placement quality above reputation, and quantitative depth above breadth. The sections below cover exactly what to ask.

Once you're in: take the quantitative modules seriously — that's the judgment layer rather than the reporting layer. Do the internship, then do another. Build one real thing with a measurable outcome. The career-hunting checklist further down turns this into a concrete list.

Entering the market: aim for roles with a number attached, and prefer smaller organizations early where accountability arrives sooner. A graduate who owns something small at 23 is on a different curve from one who supports someone else's work until 27.

The routes in — and the versions that hold up

VERSION	ASSESSMENT
Business with a strong co-op / placement year	The single most important variable. It substitutes for the vanishing analyst rung.
Operations and supply chain	Leans physical, deals with real-world constraints, scores best in the field. Chronically under-chosen.
Business with genuine quantitative depth	The judgment layer rather than the reporting layer.
Explicitly entrepreneurial tracks	Building something is the one business activity that can't be entry-level-automated.
General business, no specialization, no placement	The weakest combination in this guide, and the most commonly chosen.

Worth knowing: apprenticeship and degree-apprenticeship routes into management exist in several countries and are expanding. They pay rather than charge, and they solve the experience problem directly.

Where a business degree can take you later

The good news is genuine breadth: general management, operations, commercial and sales leadership, HR, project and program delivery, consulting, entrepreneurship, and finance-adjacent roles.

The caveat that runs through this index applies with unusual force here. In most professions, moving away from the core raises exposure. In business there is no core to move away from — so the question isn't distance from the center, it's proximity to accountability. Roles where someone owns a number score better. Roles that support other people's numbers score worse. That's the whole map, and it's worth having in mind when a program describes where its graduates end up.

What to look for in a business program

- 1. Placement — and whether it's guaranteed or competitive.** A "placement year available" that only 30% of students secure is not a placement program. Ask for the percentage.
 - 2. Real employer relationships.** Named organizations, actual pipelines, and honest conversion data.
 - 3. Quantitative content that isn't optional.** Statistics, econometrics, experimentation. This is the part that ages well.
 - 4. First-destination outcomes — job titles, not employment rates.** "94% employed" is meaningless. What are they doing?
 - 5. Specialization that's real.** An operations or supply chain pathway with genuine depth beats a general degree with a label.
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Questions to ask a business school

On placement:

- What proportion of students complete a placement or co-op, and is it guaranteed?
- Which employers took students last year, and how many converted to graduate roles?

On outcomes:

- What job titles did last year's graduates hold at six months? Read the actual list.
- What proportion were in graduate-level roles rather than any employment?
- How has that changed over three years?

On the curriculum:

- How much of the degree is quantitative, and is it compulsory?
- How does the program teach students to work with AI analysis tools — and to check them?
- What changed in the curriculum in the last two years?

Red flags: outcomes quoted only as employment rate; placement described as "available"; no named employer partners; a curriculum unchanged since 2022; heavy emphasis on generic "leadership" content with no quantitative spine.

The career-hunting checklist

Choosing well is step one. This is what turns a good choice into a good outcome once you're in — worth reading now, because the best time to pick a program is knowing exactly what you'll need to do with it. The first list is for the degree years; the second is for the job hunt that follows.

During the degree — build what can't be automated

- **Lock in a specialization with structural protection.** Operations, supply chain, or genuine quantitative depth over general management studies. The generic core is the exposed lane.
- **Treat the placement as non-negotiable.** In a field with no license, the internship is the closest thing to one, and the single strongest signal a graduate can carry. One isn't enough — do two if the program allows it.
- **Own one real, measurable thing before graduating.** A budget, a small venture, a society's P&L, a project whose outcome is yours. Evidence is the credential.
- **Get fluent with AI as a worker, not a shortcut.** Be able to direct it, catch it when it's confidently wrong, and point to a process you rebuilt and what it saved. That's the story that lands in an interview.
- **Feed curiosity and adaptability on purpose.** The tools will turn over repeatedly; the person who re-tools fastest compounds. Staying genuinely interested in how organizations work is what keeps that engine running.
- **Keep the frame wide.** Properly vet adjacent paths — operations, supply chain, a domain pairing, even the trades — before ruling them out. The most crowded lane is almost always the default one.

During the job hunt — aim, don't just apply

- **Target the protected lanes on purpose.** Ownership tracks, operations, supply chain, a domain-paired role — not "business analyst, open to anything," which points straight at the 7.6.
- **Read the title, not just the offer.** "Analyst" and "coordinator" are the automating layer. If you take one, take it as a deliberate stepping-stone with an exit in mind, not as the plan.
- **Don't grab a job just because it's on offer in an exposed lane.** A role being available doesn't make it safe. An employer still running a large analyst intake may simply be

behind the curve — and that's exactly the rung that gets cut first once they catch up. Availability today can be a lagging indicator, not a green light.

- **Prefer the number, and the smaller room.** A role with a P&L line, a target, or a team — often at a smaller organization — puts you close to accountability years sooner than supporting someone else's work at a big name.
- **Ask the employer where AI is heading in the role.** How they answer reveals whether they're building the job around these tools or waiting to be forced to. You want the former; it's the difference between a role that grows and one that's quietly being hollowed out.
- **Weigh the trajectory over the starting salary.** A slightly lower-paid role that builds ownership and AI-fluency beats a higher-paid seat in a lane that's being automated underneath you.

Go deeper — further reading

- **The Labor Market for Recent College Graduates** — *Federal Reserve Bank of New York*. The single most useful link in this guide, and free. Unemployment and underemployment by major, updated quarterly, from a central bank rather than an industry body. Look up business against nursing and engineering before making any decision.
- **Talent Disrupted: Underemployment and the Value of a College Degree** — *Burning Glass Institute and Strada Institute*. Finds 52% of graduates underemployed a year out, and — more importantly — that starting underemployed tends to be sticky rather than temporary.
- **Class of 2026: A depressed hires rate is the cause of labor market weakness for young graduates** — *Economic Policy Institute*. A careful counterweight to AI-driven explanations: the hires rate has fallen broadly, which suggests a cyclical component alongside the structural one.

The counterargument — read this one:

- **Too many college graduates flood the white-collar job market** — *Quartz*.

The argument against our score is that we're attributing to AI what is really a supply problem. On this reading, business graduate outcomes were deteriorating well before generative AI existed, driven by the sheer number of degrees conferred and by employers

raising requirements — and our 7.6 is measuring a labor market condition rather than a technological one.

Where we land: we think this is substantially correct, and we've said so above rather than hiding it. Business is the field where our framework is least sufficient on its own. What we'd add is that the two forces compound rather than compete — oversupply meant graduates already needed a differentiator, and automation removed the rung where they used to acquire one. Treat our score as one input alongside the New York Fed's underemployment data, not as a complete account.

Bottom line

Business is the field where the *program* matters more than the *subject*, and by a wider margin than anywhere else in this index. That's the good news for someone still choosing: the decision in front of you — which version, which program — is exactly the one that determines the outcome.

The destinations are good. General management, operations and commercial leadership are well-paid, varied, and protected by real accountability.

The route is the challenge, and it's a double one. Automation removed the entry rung, and it arrived on top of a graduate market where 41.5% of degree-holders are already underemployed. Business has a protected ceiling and no protected core — which means every bit of protection has to be earned, starting from a position of having none.

So the useful advice isn't "avoid business." It's: take placement more seriously than reputation, choose operations or genuine quantitative depth over general management studies, plan to get accountable for something measurable as early as possible, and interrogate first-destination job titles rather than employment rates.

And one honest thing worth saying before enrolling, if the pull toward business is really that nothing else appealed: that is the single strongest predictor of a poor outcome in this field, and it has nothing to do with AI. Business rewards people who are genuinely interested in how organizations work. It is unusually unforgiving of people who aren't — so if the interest isn't there yet, the most valuable thing you can do is look wider before you commit, not after.

Questions worth sitting with

Whether you're the one choosing or a parent thinking it through together, these are the conversations that lead to a better decision. Read "you" as whoever the choice is about.

About the work itself

1. What made business appealing? Push past "it's flexible" or "good career" to something specific. 2. **The uncomfortable one, worth asking gently:** is this a positive choice, or the thing left over after ruling other things out? Both are legitimate — but they lead to different advice. 3. What does a Tuesday look like in the job you're imagining? Compare pictures. 4. Are you interested in organizations themselves — why they work, why they fail — or in the outcomes a business career produces?

Reacting to the findings

5. Nothing in business scores below 4.9, while nursing scores 2.8 and a service electrician 2.5. Does that change anything? 6. 41.5% of recent graduates are underemployed; for nursing it's 12.8%. What do you make of that gap? 7. Which matters more to you — the ceiling being high, or the floor being absent?

The harder conversation

8. What's the plan if the first graduate role doesn't come at six months? Worth deciding before, not after. 9. Have you looked at actual first-destination job titles from your shortlisted schools, not just employment rates? 10. Does the placement year exist at each school, and is it guaranteed or competitive? Have you asked?

Testing it against reality

11. **The most valuable single action:** find someone 3–5 years into a business career and ask what they actually did in year one, and whether that job still exists in the same form. 12. Can you get any real commercial experience before or during the degree — a job with responsibility, a small venture, running something? In a field with no credential, evidence is the credential.

Widening the frame

13. If business weren't available, what would you choose? The answer usually reveals what you're actually drawn to. 14. Do you want business, or what business is made of — commercial thinking, working with people, building something, or simply a broad safe-sounding degree? Those lead to very different places, several of them cheaper and more protected. 15. Have you

looked at operations, supply chain, construction management or the trades? All score better, and all are chronically under-chosen by academically capable students.

This is analysis and informed judgment about a fast-moving situation, not a guarantee or a prediction. For business specifically, we've flagged that our framework measures automation exposure and cannot see graduate oversupply — and that the second may matter more than the first.

Scores for 2023 and 2025 are retrospectively calculated using the current methodology. Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed.

Technical scoring appendix — Business & Management

Pivotum Degree Risk Index — Fall 2026 Edition

This appendix is the audit trail. It sets out the formula, the rating anchors, every factor rating behind every track score in this profile, the backcast arithmetic, a sensitivity analysis, and the specific things that would change our mind.

We publish it because a score nobody can check is an opinion with a decimal point.

1. The formula

$$\begin{aligned} \text{Risk} = & 0.35 \times \text{Automatability} \\ & + 0.15 \times \text{EntryErosion} \\ & + 0.15 \times (10 - \text{Physical}) \\ & + 0.15 \times (10 - \text{Trust}) \\ & + 0.10 \times (10 - \text{Regulatory}) \\ & + 0.10 \times (10 - \text{Judgment}) \end{aligned}$$

Two exposure factors carry 50% of the weight; three protection factors carry 40%; judgment under novelty carries the remaining 10% and sits on the protection side. The deliberate consequence is that protection can outweigh exposure — which is why a highly automatable job like teaching still scores low.

Bands. Very low below 3.0 · Low 3.0–4.4 · Moderate 4.5–5.4 · Moderate–High 5.5–6.9 · High 7.0 and above.

2. Rating anchors

HOW THE 0–10 RAW RATINGS ARE ANCHORED

Every factor is rated on its own 0–10 scale before weighting. The anchors are identical across all twenty-eight careers, which is what makes the scores comparable.

Task automatability (A) — *what share of the working week could a capable current system already do to an acceptable standard?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Almost nothing. The work is physical, relational or wholly novel.
3–4	Administrative surround only — notes, scheduling, correspondence.
5–6	A meaningful minority of the week, mostly documentation and lookup.
7–8	A large share, including tasks central to the junior version of the role.
9–10	Most of the described duties, at or near professional standard.

Entry-path erosion (E) — *how much has the traditional route into this work narrowed?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Protected by statute or physical necessity. Training hours cannot be automated.
3–4	Stable. Some junior tasks absorbed; the apprenticeship survives.
5–6	Visible narrowing. Employers prefer experience; junior intake reduced.
7–8	Substantial. The work juniors learned on has largely gone.
9–10	The training layer and the automatable layer were the same layer.

Physical / embodied (P) — *must this be done in person, with a body, in an unpredictable setting?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Fully screen-based. Location-independent.
3–4	Occasional presence; the core work is not physical.
5–6	Regular physical presence, in largely controlled conditions.
7–8	Substantially physical, with some variability of setting.
9–10	Irreducibly physical, in conditions that differ every time.

Human trust / accountability (T) — *does someone need a specific human they can rely on, and must a human answer when it goes wrong?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Output is anonymous and reviewed by others.
3–4	Work is signed off by someone else. No personal reliance.
5–6	Some client relationship; accountability is institutional.
7–8	Named responsibility, with commercial or professional consequence.
9–10	The relationship is the service, and liability attaches personally.

Regulatory / licensing (R) — *does the law reserve this act to a qualified human?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	No license exists and none is proposed.
3–4	Certification is customary but not reserved.
5–6	Partial reservation, varying by jurisdiction or task.
7–8	Licensed practice, with some unreserved adjacent work.
9–10	Comprehensive statutory reservation, including of the training route.

Judgment under novelty (J) — *how often does the work present something with no matching precedent, where being wrong is costly?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Routine by design. Deviation is an error, not a case.
3–4	Occasional exceptions, handled by escalation.
5–6	Regular non-standard cases within a known range.
7–8	Frequent genuine novelty with material consequences.
9–10	Novelty is constant, and in some fields adversarially generated.

3. Factor ratings by track

Ratings are the Fall 2026 edition unless a range is shown. **P, T, R and J are held constant across editions** — those protections are structural and do not move on a three-year horizon. All measured movement is in A and E.

GENERAL MANAGEMENT / P&L OWNERSHIP — 4.9 (MODERATE)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	4.0	4.7	5.7	1.99
Entry-path erosion	15%	3.0	3.4	3.8	0.57
Physical / embodied	15%	2.5	2.5	2.5	1.12
Human trust / accountability	15%	8.5	8.5	8.5	0.22
Regulatory / licensing	10%	2.0	2.0	2.0	0.8
Judgment under novelty	10%	8.0	8.0	8.0	0.2
				Total	4.92 → 4.9

SUPPLY CHAIN & OPERATIONS — 5.0 (MODERATE)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	4.1	4.7	5.7	1.99
Entry-path erosion	15%	3.2	3.6	4.0	0.6
Physical / embodied	15%	3.5	3.5	3.5	0.97
Human trust / accountability	15%	7.5	7.5	7.5	0.38
Regulatory / licensing	10%	2.0	2.0	2.0	0.8
Judgment under novelty	10%	7.5	7.5	7.5	0.25
				Total	5.0 → 5.0

HR / PEOPLE — 5.3 (MODERATE)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	4.0	4.7	5.4	1.89
Entry-path erosion	15%	4.0	4.4	4.8	0.72
Physical / embodied	15%	1.5	1.5	1.5	1.27
Human trust / accountability	15%	7.5	7.5	7.5	0.38
Regulatory / licensing	10%	2.5	2.5	2.5	0.75
Judgment under novelty	10%	7.0	7.0	7.0	0.3
				Total	5.31 → 5.3

PROJECT MANAGEMENT — 6.1 (MODERATE-HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	4.1	5.0	5.8	2.03
Entry-path erosion	15%	5.0	5.6	6.2	0.93
Physical / embodied	15%	1.5	1.5	1.5	1.27
Human trust / accountability	15%	6.0	6.0	6.0	0.6
Regulatory / licensing	10%	1.5	1.5	1.5	0.85
Judgment under novelty	10%	6.0	6.0	6.0	0.4
				Total	6.08 → 6.1

BUSINESS ANALYST / COORDINATOR — 7.6 (HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	4.9	7.0	8.5	2.97
Entry-path erosion	15%	6.5	7.0	7.5	1.12
Physical / embodied	15%	1.5	1.5	1.5	1.27
Human trust / accountability	15%	4.5	4.5	4.5	0.82
Regulatory / licensing	10%	1.5	1.5	1.5	0.85
Judgment under novelty	10%	4.5	4.5	4.5	0.55
				Total	7.6 → 7.6

4. Backcast arithmetic

Worked example for the headline track, showing exactly how the three-year movement is composed.

General management / P&L ownership

EDITION	A	E	PROTECTION DEFICIT (FIXED)	SCORE
2023	4.0	3.0	2.35	4.2
2025	4.7	3.4	2.35	4.5
Fall 2026	5.7	3.8	2.35	4.9

Movement decomposition: automatability contributed **+0.59** and entry-path erosion **+0.12**, for a total of **+0.7** points over three years.

The 2023 and 2025 figures are retrospective reconstructions using the current methodology, not archived scores from published editions. They are our best assessment of what each factor would have rated at the time, given what was then demonstrable. They are not measurements.

5. Sensitivity

How far the score moves if a single factor is rated one point differently:

FACTOR	±1 POINT MOVES THE SCORE BY
Task automatability	±0.35
Entry-path erosion	±0.15
Physical / embodied	±0.15
Human trust / accountability	±0.15
Regulatory / licensing	±0.10
Judgment under novelty	±0.10

What this means in practice. A one-point disagreement about automatability moves a score by 0.35 — enough to shift a track between bands at the margins. A one-point disagreement about licensing moves it by 0.10, which almost never changes a band.

So if you disagree with one of our numbers, the automatability rating is where the disagreement matters most, and it is the rating we would most want challenged.

6. Stated limitations

We measure capability, not deployment. Scores reflect exposure to what AI can already do at the leading edge — not how much any particular employer has adopted. Adoption lags capability by years and lags unevenly: large, well-funded organisations first; small, rural, public-sector and thin-margin employers much later. The lag is a buffer, not a shelter. It buys time without changing direction.

We do not measure demand. A task can be highly automatable and highly in demand simultaneously. Where the labor market and our framework disagree, we say so in the profile rather than adjusting the score to fit.

We do not measure oversupply. The number of people entering a field is outside our six factors, and for some careers it matters more than automation.

We do not measure industry economics. A profession can contract for reasons entirely unrelated to technology.

We do not measure whether the work is worth doing. Pay, satisfaction, debt, hours and meaning sit outside the score and are covered separately in each profile — often at greater length, because for several careers they matter more.

Sub-track definitions are ours. Job titles vary between employers and countries. We have chosen tracks that reflect genuinely different work, not official classifications.

7. What would change our mind

Each edition names specific, checkable indicators. If these move, the scores move — including downward.

Across the index:

- **Graduate hiring share.** If employers in the professions where we rate entry-path erosion highly return to hiring juniors at pre-2023 rates, those ratings fall.
- **Content of mandated training hours.** Several professions protect their on-ramp through required supervised experience. If the content of those hours shifts from producing work to supervising it, the protection weakens without any rule changing.
- **Offsite and prefabricated construction share.** The clearest test of our physical-protection ratings: automation performs well in controlled settings, so moving work indoors raises exposure without any robotics breakthrough.
- **Verified deployment rather than capability.** If adoption stalls materially below capability for several editions, our leading-indicator approach is overstating near-term risk and we will say so.

We will report movement in either direction. A framework that only ever revises upward is not measuring anything.

Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed. The 2023 and 2025 figures are retrospective reconstructions using the current methodology.